

HERITAGE

GIVING THE PAST A FUTURE

The restoration of the **Qutb Shahi** complex in Hyderabad can be a template for other preservation efforts



By 2013, parts of the *baolis* (ancient step-wells) inside Hyderabad's centuries-old Qutb Shahi tomb complex had collapsed. Rubble had collected. Granite stone blocks were missing. The park itself, a vast and wondrous necropolis, containing the tombs of the Golconda kings, lay dilapidated and ignored. But last month, 10 years after restoration commenced here, it was recognised with a UNESCO award of distinction.

"It was just like any other neglected monument—over a period of time, they get lost to encroachments, demolition, destruction," says Arvind Kumar, special chief secretary of Telangana's urban development department. "Yes, it's a slow journey [of restoration], but a very meaningful one, and we feel very proud of the way it is coming up now."

Work began in 2013, following a Memorandum of Understanding between the state government, the local authority and the Aga Khan Trust for Culture. The Trust has previously been recognised for its work on Delhi's Sunder Nursery and Nizamuddin Basti.

Rulers of the Qutb Shahi dynasty and other nobles are buried in the 106-acre park that contains more than 100 structures, built over the 16th and 17th centuries. Quli Qutb Shah, the founder of the dynasty, and Muhammad Quli Qutb Shah, who built Hyderabad in 1591, both lie here. Over their 169-year reign, the Qutb Shahis ruled vast swathes of southern India.

"The idea was that we should restore and revive all the possible sites, so that Hyderabad, with its rich cultural and heritage background, can be declared a UNESCO heritage city,"